from the Nationalist Chinese Ambassador in Turkey to the Indian Ambassador there, for India to mediate between Chiang Kai-shek and Mao Zedong, was rejected by the Government of India. Nehru correctly surmised that the KMT regime was collapsing and that it was a 'bankrupt government in China now'. [8] Facts were to prove the veracity of India's strategic assessment of the internal situation in China. This assessment gave it a head start in building ties with the new regime in China.

Both the Government of India and the Chinese Communist Party began to give serious consideration to such a possibility by the beginning of 1949. They approached this matter, however, from very different perspectives. What were the factors that guided the thinking of the Indian government on this question? Nehru's personal convictions certainly played a part in it. He believed that an Asian resurgence in the post-war period would be possible only with China as a major player. He said so at the Asian Relations Conference in April 1947, on the eve of Indian independence, when he called China 'that great country to which Asia owes so much and from which so much is expected'. [9]

There were other reasons, too, for India to contemplate early recognition of the new Communist regime in China. The first of these was India's northern frontier and its relationship to the status of Tibet. President Chiang Kai-shek's government had, after India's independence, reiterated that Tibet was a part of China, that the Simla Agreement of 1914 was no longer valid, and that it did not acknowledge the McMahon Line as the boundary. The Government of India was aware of the Chinese Communists' intention to 'liberate' Tibet. A report from the Indian Political Officer in Gangtok (Sikkim) to the Ministry of External Affairs, stating that the 'occupation or domination of Tibet by a potentially hostile and possibly aggressive